

PROVIDENCE ENGLISH PRIVATE SCHOOL

Anti-Bullying Policy

2026 - 2027

Approved for FS2 – Year 13

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1. Aims & Objectives

At Providence English Private School (PEPS), we believe that all children and young people have the right to an educational environment where they feel safe and which is free from harassment and bullying, whether that behaviour occurs in person, on school premises, or online.

This policy is implemented in partnership with the school's Behaviour & Discipline Policy, Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy and Wellbeing Policy, and serves the entire school from FS2 to Year 13.

- To inform students and parents of our expectations in order to ensure a productive partnership, where everyone has a role to play in eradicating bullying;
- To maintain a community in which everyone feels valued and safe and where individual differences are appreciated, understood and accepted;
- To promote a secure, happy and caring environment where kindness and helpfulness are expected and respected;
- To praise and reward positive behaviour which benefits others and the community as a whole;
- To teach students to respect themselves and others, promoting healthy self-esteem;
- To reduce the emotional and mental distress caused by bullying, upholding every student's right to enjoy their time at school;
- To meet the requirements of the UAE National Policy for the Prevention of Bullying in Educational Institutions and the National Policy for Child Protection in Educational Institutions.

2. Legal & Regulatory Framework

This policy is written to align with the following UAE federal, local and regulatory requirements:

- **Sharjah Private Education Authority (SPEA):** safeguarding, wellbeing and behaviour standards, including transparent recording and review of bullying incidents and student/parent voice in the process;
- **UAE National Policy for the Prevention of Bullying in Educational Institutions:** sets out the school's responsibility to prevent, identify and respond to bullying, and to appoint a designated Child Protection Coordinator;
- **UAE National Policy for Child Protection in Educational Institutions:** requires schools to maintain a safe learning environment, appoint a Child Protection Coordinator, and establish clear reporting mechanisms;
- **Federal Law No. 3 of 2016 on Child Rights (Wadeema's Law):** guarantees every child's right to protection from all forms of abuse, including online harm;
- **Federal Decree-Law No. 34 of 2021 (Cybercrime Law):** addresses online harassment, impersonation, defamation and the non-consensual sharing of images, and carries significant legal penalties for offenders;
- **Ministry of Education national anti-bullying initiatives:** school participation in national awareness campaigns and reporting channels, including MOE and Ministry of Interior hotlines.

3. Scope & Applicability

This policy applies to all students, staff, volunteers, contractors, parents and visitors connected with PEPS. It covers behaviour:

- On school premises during the school day;
- On school transport, and before and after school on school grounds;
- During school trips, fixtures, events and any school-organised activity off-site;

- In digital spaces, including social media, messaging apps and online learning platforms, at any time where the conduct affects a member of the PEPS community.

4. Bullying: Definition & Forms

Bullying is any behaviour which is deliberately intended to hurt, threaten, frighten or discriminate against another individual or group. It is usually unprovoked, happens repeatedly as part of a pattern of behaviour, and can continue over a long period of time. A single unkind incident is treated seriously but is addressed under the Behaviour & Discipline Policy unless it forms part of a repeated pattern.

Bullying can take a number of forms:

- **Physical:** pushing, kicking, hitting, pinching, hair-pulling and other forms of violence or threats of violence;
- **Verbal:** name-calling, sarcasm and insults;
- **Innuendo:** spreading rumours and persistent teasing;
- **Emotional/Social:** excluding, ridicule, humiliation and deliberate isolation from peer groups;
- **Discriminatory:** targeting a student's race, religion, nationality, gender, disability, culture or appearance;
- **Sexual:** unwanted physical contact or abusive comments of a sexual nature;
- **Cyberbullying/Digital:** harassing messages or posts; exclusion from group chats; image or video-based abuse; impersonation or fake accounts; doxxing; and persistent contact through social media, messaging apps or online games designed to upset or abuse a student.

5. Roles & Responsibilities

- **Child Protection Coordinator:** named lead responsible for overseeing all bullying and child protection concerns, liaising with SPEA/MOE, and ensuring cases are recorded and followed up.
- **Anti-Bullying Committee:** comprising the Child Protection Coordinator, school social worker, school nurse and a member of the Senior Leadership Team, meeting regularly to review incidents and prevention strategies.
- **Teachers & Staff:** responsible for modelling respectful behaviour, remaining alert to signs of bullying, and reporting concerns promptly.
- **Students:** expected to treat one another with respect and to report bullying they experience or witness.
- **Parents:** expected to work in partnership with the school, report concerns promptly, and support the school's response.

6. Prevention Strategies

- Run a school-wide programme on anti-bullying, including assemblies and presentations, that informs and educates students and gives them strategies to deal with situations they may encounter;
- Support students through advice and counselling to make positive choices and resist peer pressure;
- Listen to all parties involved in incidents and take allegations from victims seriously;
- Reassure students that the school will do all in its power to protect and support everyone involved while issues are resolved;
- Model, as a school community, the values in which we believe;
- Investigate all incidents as fully as possible;
- Use a range of strategies to challenge bullying behaviour, including restorative approaches;
- Include opportunities within the curriculum to discuss bullying and other forms of anti-social behaviour, including online safety;

- Identify bullying behaviour at an early stage and work towards behaviour modification before it becomes more serious;
- Implement peer mentoring or student ambassador programmes;
- Mark national initiatives such as UAE Bullying Prevention campaigns to reinforce positive messaging;
- Promote inclusive classroom environments that value diversity.

7. Reporting Bullying

PEPS encourages a culture where victims and witnesses feel safe to speak up. All reports, however trivial they may seem at first, are treated seriously.

7.1 Reporting Channels

- Students or parents may report a concern to any teacher, the school counsellor, the school social worker, or the Child Protection Coordinator;
- An anonymous reporting option (social.worker@pepsschool.ae) is available for students or parents who prefer not to report in person;
- All staff must remain alert to changes in a student's behaviour, attitude and wellbeing, and report concerns immediately to the Child Protection Coordinator;
- Suspected cyberbullying must be reported promptly and, where it may constitute a criminal offence under the UAE Cybercrime Law, escalated to the Principal and, where appropriate, the relevant authorities.

8. Responding to Bullying

As a school, we will:

- Take all bullying concerns seriously and assess the needs of each student individually;
- Regard all incidents as potentially serious and investigate them thoroughly, normally beginning within two school days of a report;
- Interview those alleged to be bullying and those affected separately, and gather witness information;
- Keep a written record of the incident, investigation and outcome, recorded on the school's incident system (e1) and shared with relevant staff and the Child Protection Coordinator;
- Take action to prevent further incidents, which may include:
 - Imposition of sanctions such as detention or removal of privileges;
 - Requiring a sincere apology;
 - Informing the parents of both the student affected and the student responsible;
 - Providing ongoing support for both the student affected and the student responsible, including counselling where appropriate.

Where an incident may also constitute a safeguarding concern or a criminal offence, this policy operates alongside, and does not replace, the school's Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy and applicable UAE law.

9. Policy Links

- Behaviour & Discipline Policy
- Safeguarding & Child Protection Policy
- Wellbeing Policy
- E-Safety / Acceptable Use Policy

10. Monitoring & Evaluation

The Child Protection Coordinator, in partnership with the Safeguarding & Child Protection lead, is responsible for monitoring and evaluating this policy on an ongoing basis. This policy will be reviewed annually by the Senior Leadership Team and Wellness Team, or sooner if required by changes in SPEA/MOE regulation.

Appendices / Annexures

1. Incident Reporting Form
2. Conflict Resolution Procedure
3. Behaviour Memo

Policy Reviewed By	Social Worker & Senior Leadership Team
Policy Reviewed Date	August 2026
Policy Approved By	School Principal
Next Review Date	September 2027